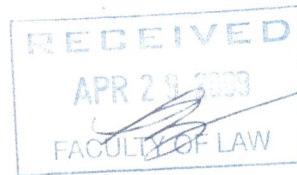


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Words from behind the walls



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April 29, 2009

(Jackson)

Preface

When I signed up to take your class, it was really just so I could see what the inside of a prison looks like. I do not intend to go into criminal law, and I thought that this would likely be my only chance to see what things looked like from the other side of the bars. I did not have any great interest in the plight of prisoners in Canadian institutions. If I am to be perfectly honest, I did not care. Part of me believed that if a person did a terrible thing, they deserved to live in terrible conditions and suffer as punishment for the suffering they had caused others to endure. I was one of the people who believed that simply being incarcerated was not necessarily sufficient punishment, but that having to live in hellish conditions was part of the punishment. I was never one who advocated or believed in poor treatment of inmates by prison guards, nor did I believe in deprivation of basic human rights, but I did believe that prison life should be a thoroughly unpleasant experience.

I had always empathized with victims of crime, and had tried to imagine how I would feel about a person who had committed a horrible wrong against me or someone I loved. I always imagined that I would want that person to rot in a tiny, miserable cell for as long as they could be kept there. I made no distinction between the person who committed the crime and the crime itself. In my mind, the criminal *was* his crime.

Between the time I signed up for your class and the start of the semester, I had two experiences that had begun to change my perspective of prisons and prisoners. The first was when I met my friend Karen from Norway when we were both on exchange in Scotland. She is a cute little Norwegian girl, not more than five feet tall, and one of the sweetest people I have ever met. She is also a prison guard at Stavanger Prison in Norway. To say that I was shocked to learn this would be an understatement. I kept trying to figure out how this sweet (and tiny) young woman could be a guard at a medium security prison, guarding some of the most dangerous criminals in Norway. I asked her what it was like doing the

job that she did. She said that she really enjoyed it, and that she liked speaking with the inmates. She told me that they were very interesting and often very nice people. They were kind to her, and she would often spend time with them just sitting and playing cards. I asked if she was every afraid to be in such close proximity to people who had proven themselves to be violent criminals. She told me that, while they had all done very bad things, they were not necessarily bad people, and that she just tried to put aside what they had done and treat them like she would treat anyone else. It was after this conversation that I began to think that maybe my perspective on prisons and prisoners was a bit skewed.

My next perspective-changing experience came during my time in Dublin. I had been told that one of the interesting things to see in the city was Kilmainham Gaol. I was not sure what to expect when I arrived, but what I saw was certainly more than I ever could have imagined. It was one of the most haunting (and probably haunted) places I have ever visited. It was originally built to house 120 prisoners, but at its peak held around nine thousand men, women, and children. It was built with the goal of keeping prisoners separate from each other, where each would have his own cell with one tiny glassless, barred window to the outside world. The newer wing was built in the style of Foucault's panopticon, so every cell could be viewed from a single point in the room, and inmates would never know when they were being watched. I was told that when the prison was still operational, there was carpeting along the main hall so that inmates would not be able to hear the footsteps of the guards, so would never know if a guard was coming to look through the peephole in the cell door. This was a place of public hangings, firing squads, and people living in degrading, squalid conditions. We were told stories about some of the prisoners and were given the opportunity to read some of the letters they had written to their families while they were jailed in Kilmainham. This was the first time I had really thought about what prison life might be like for the prisoners who had to live there. It was terrifying.

When I arrived in your class, I was still unsure of where I stood in relation to my feelings about prisons and the people who live in them. As appalled as I had been with what I had seen at Kilmainham, I kept telling myself that it was not the same because that was how things were in troubled times in Ireland, not how things were today in Canada. We were not locking people up because of their political beliefs or because they stole food to feed their families, we were locking them up because they had done horrible things. And, while I kept in mind the conversation I had had with my friend Karen, I still found myself unable to separate the criminal from the crime. I think the most accurate way to describe my feelings about the situations of prisoners in Canadian prisons was confusion.

As I began to hear your stories about inmates, their experiences, and the conditions that they lived in, my confusion deepened. I was still torn between embracing the logic that I saw in your book and heard in your words and the feelings that I had held so long about prisoners being deserving of whatever faced them in prison. I think the shift in my feelings came when you showed us the video from Kwikwexwelhp. The men in that video did not look the way I had always imagined criminals to look. By this I mean that they did not appear to be the monsters I had always imagined when I had pictured what a murderer or an armed robber would appear to be. They were just like anyone else.

The visit to Matsqui was the real turning point for me. I was not sure what to expect when we arrived, but I am not sure that I was prepared for the reality of it. That visit had a profound effect on me. I kept finding myself wondering how I could have failed to separate these men from their crimes for so long. After all, I have now had two classmates in my lifetime (that I know of) who have killed, and I know that they are not monsters. I was shocked. And I was so moved by what some of these men had to say. Some of them have been in prison as long as I have been alive, yet if I had met any one of them on the street, I would never have thought, now there is a hardened criminal, or a bank robber, or a killer.

After that visit I have had many conversations with classmates, friends, and family about crime, prisons, and prisoners. I have challenged those who hold the beliefs that I used to cling to so strongly that there must be a better way. I was saddened when I heard about the new plan to take away more rights from prisoners. It just does not seem right.

For my final project, I did not want to give you just another research paper. I thought something more reflective would be appropriate as this truly is my final project of my academic career. I am a hobby poet, and I found inspiration in some of the words that I read and heard from the inmates you introduces us to. I would like to share some of those words with you here.

Thank you for a wonderful class.

Choice

One bad decision
One wrong turn
That is why I am here
That is all that separates us

We started out the same
With hopes and dreams and endless possibilities
Then I said yes and you said no
That is all that separates us

We both know the law
I have been beaten by it, you have used it to beat me
Now I stare out at you through these bars
That is all that separates us

Hope

"I can't wait to get out of here",
He tells me
"Only three more months to go"
His face is so full of hope
There is a light behind his eyes
"Got a job all lined up
Got my family, my mom"
His family is his guiding force
They are a reason to get out
"This time it will be different
This time I won't come back
I am never coming back
To this place"

Respect

Respect does not exist for us

Everyone out there sees only the bad

Someday they will see that what we are

People first, prisoners second

Every day they talk about

Correcting us, but

Time is all we have to do

Home

I've been in 23 years
I have no family
I have no friends
I have no community
I have no hope

They open my door and tell me that I am free
Free to do what
This place is all I know
This is my home
This is my world

I step out into the rain
I walk toward the gate
There is a plastic water bottle impaled on the razor wire
I always thought that would be the only way out

I am more scared to leave
Than I was when I got here
That was another lifetime
Back then I had hope
Now I have nothing but eighty dollars in a savings account
That doesn't get you much these days

I am a free man
But I have never felt less free
I have nowhere to go
I am shut out of my home
I turn back around and start banging on the doors
Let me back in
This is all wrong
I just want to come home